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The ACTS Prayer Model — A Framework for Deeper, Richer Prayer

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I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men.

— **1 Timothy 2:1** [Read on Bible.eu →](#)

What Is the ACTS Prayer Model?

Have you ever sat down to pray and felt like you were just rambling? Maybe you jumped straight to asking God for things, or you ran out of words after thirty seconds. You are not alone. Most of us have been there, and it does not mean something is wrong with your prayer life — it just means you could use a little structure.

That is exactly what the ACTS prayer model provides. ACTS is an acronym that stands for **Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, and Supplication**. It is a simple framework that guides

you through four dimensions of prayer, helping you move beyond a wish list and into a genuine, full-hearted conversation with God.

The model is not a formula or a magic spell. It is more like a trail map — it shows you the path, but you get to walk it at your own pace. Whether you have been praying for decades or you are just [learning how to pray](#), the ACTS model can breathe fresh life into your time with God.



A — Adoration

Adoration is where prayer begins — and it is where most of us skip ahead. We are so eager to tell God what we need that we forget to stop and marvel at who He is. But starting with adoration  shifts your entire perspective. Instead of approaching God as a vending machine, you come to Him as a child looking up at a loving, mighty Father.

Adoration is not about flattering God. He does not need our compliments. It is about aligning your heart with reality — recognizing that the God you are speaking to is holy, powerful, compassionate, and faithful beyond measure. When you begin by praising His character, your worries shrink and your [faith](#) grows.

The [Book of Psalms](#) is overflowing with adoration. Psalm 145:3 says, "Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised; and his greatness is unsearchable." You can borrow the psalmist's words or use your own. Here are some ways to practice adoration:

Praise His attributes — "God, You are faithful. You never break a promise."

Reflect on His names — Jehovah Jireh (Provider), El Shaddai (God Almighty), Prince of Peace

Worship through creation — "Lord, the sunrise this morning reminded me of Your beauty and creativity."

Pray Scripture — Read a Psalm of praise aloud as your own prayer (try [Psalm 23](#) or Psalm 100)

C — Confession

After lifting your eyes to God in adoration, the natural response is to see yourself more clearly — and that means confronting the gap between who God is and who you have been lately. Confession is not about wallowing in shame. It is about honesty. It is bringing what is broken into the light so God can heal it.

[First John 1:9](#) gives us this beautiful promise: "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness." Confession is not earning forgiveness — it is receiving what [grace](#) has already made available.

Be specific in your confession. Instead of "God, forgive me for everything," try naming what weighs on your heart: "God, I was impatient with my children yesterday. I spoke harshly when I should have spoken with [kindness](#). Forgive me and help me do better." Specificity leads to real change.

Confession also means turning — not just feeling sorry, but asking God for the strength to walk in a new direction. The Bible calls this [repentance](#), and it is one of the most freeing things you will ever experience.



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T — Thanksgiving

There is a subtle but important difference between adoration and thanksgiving. Adoration praises God for who He is; thanksgiving thanks God for what He has done. Both matter, and they work together beautifully.

[Gratitude](#) is one of the most powerful spiritual habits you can develop. When you train yourself to notice God's blessings — even on hard days — it rewires how you see the world. Paul wrote in

1 Thessalonians 5:18, "In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you."

Thanksgiving might include:

Answered prayers — "Thank You, Lord, for healing my friend."

Daily provisions — "Thank You for food on our table, a roof over our heads, and clothes on our backs."

Relationships — "Thank You for my family, my church, my friends who support me."

Spiritual blessings — "Thank You for [salvation](#), for Your Word, for the Holy Spirit's guidance."

Hard things that grew you — "Thank You for that difficult season that taught me to depend on You."

Keeping a prayer journal where you write down things you are thankful for can transform your prayer life. When you look back over weeks and months of recorded blessings, your faith will soar.

S — Supplication



Now you bring your requests. After you have praised God, confessed your heart, and given thanks, your spirit is in the right place to ask. Notice that supplication comes last — not because your needs do not matter, but because the first three steps prepare your heart to ask with the right perspective.

[Philippians 4:6](#) says, "Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God." God invites you to bring everything — big and small, urgent and long-term.

Supplication has two dimensions:

Personal requests — Your own needs: [healing](#), direction, provision, [strength](#), wisdom

Intercession — Praying on behalf of others: family members, friends, church leaders, your community, the world

Be bold in your asking. [Matthew 7:7](#) records Jesus saying, "Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you." God does not promise to answer exactly as we wish, but He promises to hear and to respond with [wisdom](#) and love.

Putting ACTS into Practice

The best way to learn the ACTS model is to simply start using it. Here are some practical suggestions:

Tips for Practicing the ACTS Model

1

Set a Consistent Time

Morning, evening, or lunch — pick a time that works and protect it. Start with 10 minutes and let it grow naturally.

2

Use a Prayer Journal

Write one or two items under each letter. Over time, your journal becomes a record of God's faithfulness.

3

Pray Scripture

Use Psalms for adoration, 1 John 1:9 for confession, and Philippians 4:6 for supplication. Scripture fuels prayer.

4

Be Flexible

ACTS is a guide, not a cage. Some days you may linger in adoration. Other days, your heart may overflow with requests.

Remember: the ACTS model is a servant, not a master. It exists to help you pray more fully, not to make prayer feel like homework. If you find yourself deeply engaged in thanksgiving and you never quite get to supplication, that is perfectly fine. God is not grading your prayer on structure — He is delighted that you showed up. 

For more on building a consistent prayer habit, see our [beginner's guide to prayer](#) and our [Bible study guide](#) for pairing prayer with Scripture reading.

A Sample ACTS Prayer

If you want to see what an ACTS prayer sounds like in practice, here is a simple example you can personalize:

Adoration: *Father, You are holy and perfect. You are the Creator of the heavens and the earth, the God who sees me and knows me by name. Your love is steadfast and Your faithfulness reaches to the clouds. I praise You for Your mercy that is new every morning.*

Confession: *Lord, I confess that I have been anxious this week instead of trusting You. I have let worry consume my thoughts when I should have been resting in Your promises. Forgive*

me for trying to carry burdens that belong to You.

Thanksgiving: *Thank You for my family, for health, for the breath in my lungs right now. Thank You for answering my prayer about that situation at work. Thank You for Your Word that guides me and comforts me.*

Supplication: *Lord, I ask for wisdom as I make this decision. Please heal my mother and give her peace. Protect my children today. Draw my neighbor closer to You. Give our church leaders discernment and courage. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

This is just one example. Your ACTS prayer will sound different from mine, and that is exactly how it should be. God is not looking for perfect prose — He is looking for an honest heart.

Family Discussion & Activity

| DISCUSSION QUESTIONS



- ? Which of the four ACTS steps comes most naturally to you? Which one is hardest? Why do you think that is?
- ? What is one thing about God's character that you truly admire? (This is adoration!)
- ? Can you name three things you are thankful for right now that you have never thanked God for out loud?
- ? Is there someone in your life right now who really needs prayer? What would you ask God for on their behalf?

| FAMILY ACTIVITY

Pray through the ACTS model together as a family. Give each person a piece of paper divided into four sections labeled A, C, T, and S. Spend a few quiet minutes writing one or two items in each section. Then go around the circle and share — each person reads their Adoration, then Confession (they can keep this private if they prefer), then Thanksgiving, then Supplication. Close by praying together for each other's requests.

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I have to follow the ACTS order exactly?



How long should an ACTS prayer take?



Can children use the ACTS prayer model?



What if I get stuck on the confession part?



Is the ACTS model found in the Bible?



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